

B

BALJEET SINGH, a 60-year-old farmer from Punjab, had never given much thought to healthcare, aside from the occasional visit to the local doctor for treating a common cold or fever.

All that changed last year, when his wife was diagnosed with cancer. The nearest cancer treatment facility was hours away, and the cost of advanced therapies like chemotherapy seemed insurmountable. The doctor advised Singh to seek specialised treatment, but he didn't know how he could finance such expensive treatment.

Singh's struggles are emblematic of issues faced by millions across the country: the gap between available healthcare services and the affordability of treatments. India's healthcare system is expanding, but it remains deeply uneven, leaving too many like Singh without timely access to essential services.

Singh and many like him are pinning hopes on the government addressing some of these concerns. In fact, it isn't just patients and carers who are looking for some aid in the upcoming Union Budget 2025-26; stakeholders within the healthcare sector—from hospitals to pharmaceutical companies to medical technology (med-tech) firms—are also hoping for some beneficial measures. They are calling for critical policy interventions to accelerate growth, enhance infrastructure, and ensure affordable access to healthcare.

63

EASING THE BURDEN

Healthcare industry stakeholders have called for a reduction on import duty and GST on medical devices to make healthcare more accessible

PHOTO BY **CHANDRADEEP KUMAR**

THE HEALTHCARE SECTOR IS EXPECTED TO RECEIVE A SHOT IN THE ARM IN BUDGET 2025-26, WITH A FOCUS ON PRIMARY HEALTHCARE, DIGITAL HEALTH, AND BOOSTING PHARMACEUTICAL MANUFACTURING AND RESEARCH. BUT CHALLENGES LIKE THE SHORTAGE OF HEALTHCARE PROFESSIONALS REMAIN

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA